

Company: IDFC FIRST Bank

Job Profile:

Offer Type: Internship + Placement

CTC: 18.10 LPA (Fixed: 14 LPA + Joining Bonus: 2 L + Variable: 2.10 LPA)

Location: Mumbai/Bangalore/Hyderabad/Chennai

Resume:  Nimit_Sheth_Resume (14).pdf

Contact: 8291949073

Process Date: PPT - 25/07 (online)

OA - 28/07

Interviews - 30/07

If you're going through hell, keep going. - Winston Churchill

This is the most relevant quote for your entire placement journey. During your preparation phase before the placement season starts, when giving OAs for companies, before interviews, during interviews, after interviews and when you face rejections after multiple interviews, at each phase you will go through hell but you will come out victorious at the end. The key is to keep going, even if you're facing continuous rejections and feel that there is no hope. The best will come when you least expect it.

Placement Process:

1. Online Assessment Round [137 students appeared for this round]

This was the initial screening phase which consisted of three sections:

- a. Aptitude Section (15 questions)
- b. CS Fundamentals (20-30 questions)
- c. Coding Section (2 questions)

The aptitude section consisted of pattern recognition, profit and loss, ratios, statistics. In the CS Fundamentals section questions were based on Core CS, DBMS, OS, SQL and questions based on output prediction using flowcharts/ code snippets. The coding section had two questions as follows:

I. Given an array of integers, find out which numbers would be at the same place and which numbers would have changed positions after sorting the array. (I was able to pass all but one test cases i.e. 9/10)

II. Given a range of numbers X, Y you had to find the sum of all golden numbers. A golden number would be defined such that the sum of its digits - maximum digit out of all digits is equal to the maximum digit. (eg: 3003: sum = 6, max_digit = 3, sum - max_digit = 3). (I was able pass 9/12 test cases)

Important Tips for OA:

1. Time management is the most important aspect of an OA. You must attempt easy and especially short questions first and then go to longer ones. Understand what the question is asking before jumping to the answer and sometimes just try option elimination if nothing works.
2. Keep 30-45 seconds at the end reserved for unattempted questions. This time is basically for those questions that you have absolutely no idea how to answer. You quickly select random options for these and since there are no -ve marks make sure to attempt each question.
3. For aptitude questions refer to IndiaBix and make sure to study up on statistics formulas as they are usually asked in IDFC OAs.
4. For the coding section, the questions for any company are never straightforward; they will give some kind of a pointless story which will take you a minute or two to read and some more minutes to comprehend. These won't be your typical LeetCode questions. I would suggest that toward the end of your preparation phase practice a few of these questions by asking ChatGPT to generate such lengthy story based company OA style questions.

2. **Technical Round 1** [40-45 students were selected for this round]

The round started with the interviewer asking me to take him through my resume. Keep this about 60-90 secs max. Then from my introduction he picked up my experience in python and started asking me questions on the language. These basic to in depth questions about the language and its working. He asked me about break, continue & pass, list vs tuple, lambdas, docstring, memory management, garbage collection in python etc. I managed to answer almost all them. The main reason was that I had studied the "Python interview questions" from GeeksforGeeks and most of the questions were exactly the same or similar to it so make sure to study those. Then he asked me some questions on C++ like virtual functions, friend keyword, multiple inheritance and the diamond problem etc.

Then he asked me if I knew anything about Operating Systems to which I said I had basic understanding of multithreading and processes which was taught to us in our academics and in theory. He asked me how to run a python program on a UNIX server which I did not. Then he asked about thrashing in an OS which I again wasn't aware of.

Next he moved on to DBMS and Schema design. He gave me a situation where I had to design the schema for a hotel which took bookings from customers on their own website and aggregators like MakeMyTrip, TripAdvisor etc. I designed the schema and at each stage communicated with the interviewer on my choice and he would give me hints and direct me if I was drifting in the wrong direction. After a lot of cancellations and reiterations I arrived at the final schema. Keep in mind to keep explaining why you were adding certain tables or columns in your schema. Next he asked to write an SQL query to find the number of room bookings in each quarter which I wrote very easily. He then asked me to update this to find the percentage occupancy in each quarter. He then connected this database scenario to techno-hr questions. He put me in a situation where if I got a call from a customer saying that they had booked a room and made the payment but did not receive a confirmation what would I do. Then he changed it to the booking type being a third party aggregator and the booking of the customer was the next day. I connected this with a situation which I had actually faced during the Coldplay concert in Ahmedabad where our hotel denied us the online booking we had done after reaching there.

After he was satisfied with all my answers and a few follow ups, he was finally done and asked me if I had any questions. Make sure to prepare 2-3 good questions based on the company for this beforehand as this creates a great impression and shows that you are serious about the company. I asked him about the GenAI and ML projects that the company had been working on and would be undertaking for internal tools as well as consumer facing tools.

PRO Tips for Technical Rounds:

1. Make ChatGPT your friend as there is no better tool for interview preparations.
2. Know your resume forwards and backwards without missing a single piece of information. Also prepare for in-depth questions for each part of the resume. Sometimes an interview might take a point in your resume and ask very in-depth questions to test your understanding. Use ChatGPT for this and ask it to give curveball questions too.
3. Make sure to keep the points in your resume as honest as possible and don't mention something you lack understanding in. If extremely necessary to include a part you might not know about, make sure to understand it in-depth one day before the interview. Keep in mind that the interviewer is sitting with a laptop and you're not.
4. I would advise that you learn OOPs concepts in Java as a lot of companies have Java as a requirement or at least have some projects of Java in their systems. Then learn those same concepts in your preferred language.
5. For each language you mention in your resume, go through its interview questions from GFG because a lot of times they cover almost everything about the language.
6. Technical Interviews are as much a psychological game as they are about your technical skills. The interviewers will ask you questions on what you have mentioned in your resume and based on what you answer. Make sure to drop hints of where you want to lead them. A lot of the time they might end up asking exactly that.
7. Be confident and honest in your answers and if you are asked something you don't know or to write a code whose syntax you do not recall, try explaining the concept and approach and related concepts you know. Most of the time that is what interviewers are looking for. If there comes a point where you have absolutely no clue of what you are asked, just be straight with them and say that you haven't learnt or worked with this particular concept instead of making up a useless explanation.
8. This is to be followed for all interviews and this is one of the most important aspects of an interview, keep a good eye contact with the interviewer. This might not seem like anything but it conveys that you are confident in your abilities and your answers, otherwise you come across as underconfident especially during HR interviews.

3. **Technical Round 2** [22 students were shortlisted for this round]

The round again began with a typical "Introduce yourself". Then they gave me scenarios and told me to identify what data structures would be used in those scenarios. The first scenario was that there were usernames and each had details which would have to be accessed so what DS would be used to which I answered HashMap for $O(1)$ lookups. Then he updated the scenario such that the details of the user would need to be updated constantly. I was still adamant on using a HashMap since lookups would be $O(1)$ but that was not what they wanted. After the interview I realized that they were expecting me to consider this as a normal database and looking for the answer to be B-Trees which are used for data storage in SQL and NoSQL Databases.

Next they moved on to OOPs where they asked me to write one or two codes in Java. Next they jumped to Exception Handling and asked me what it was in Java. I told them about checked and unchecked exceptions and try catch. They asked me if it was possible to create custom exceptions in Java and then asked me to write code for a custom exception. I did not remember the exact syntax but I still wrote what I remembered and then explained it to them. Then I was asked about the difference between Exception and RuntimeException and why I inherited the RuntimeException class in my custom exception class. Next came questions on Object class of Java and what equals method is in Java. I knew about Object class being

the topmost class of Java which all classes inherited from but was not aware of equals so told them it was a method of the String class then they said it was of Object class.

Now they moved on to 1-2 questions from my resume. I was asked why I used the Llama2 Model in my internship to which I explained about the company's requirements of privacy and budget constraints. Then they saw Git and GitHub and asked the main difference between them. Then they gave a situation where there are two branches one is the main branch and another is the dev branch where a feature was being developed. Say a developer was working on a feature in the dev branch and a constraint was to be created that they could push the code automatically once there were no merge conflicts. I suggested using admin approval before the code was pushed but they wanted it to be done automatically to which I did not know the answer.

Additional Tips for Technical Round:

1. Prepare a clear introduction of yourself well before the interviews. Don't ever think that you can wing it, but at the same time do not rote the intro, prepare points that you want to convey and define a clear flow.
2. Keep your introduction short but make it a story where each point connects to the next and relate it to the role. Also set clear boundaries about what you do and don't know in the intro itself. For example I had used Python for ML and data projects, C++ for DSA and recently learnt Java only for OOPs so I made this very clear in the introduction. This ensures that the interviewer doesn't ask you anything out of scope. The more generalized your introduction is, the more curveballs you could potentially face.

3. **HR Round** [9 students were shortlisted for this round]

This was your typical HR interview where the interviewer was trying to get to know you and understand if your values aligned with that of the company's. The interview started with her asking me the purpose of this HR interview. Next she asked me to tell her about my resume and something that wasn't in it. Then she asked me about the challenges I have overcome. I was asked what my ideal company would look like where I would enjoy working at. Then I was asked about my ideal manager who I would love to work with to which I connected to my experience where I had talked to a senior of mine who was working at IDFC currently and the way he helped me, worked like a charm. Then I was asked what I knew about IDFC and why I wanted to work there. Next came the Work from home vs Work from office question. I was asked what my thoughts were about both of them and which of them I believed in, be sure to support your answer with adequate reasoning. Then she gave me a situation where I was the team lead for a project for a very important stakeholder who had given us a hard deadline but I found out that it would be impossible to deliver at that date. What would be my approach to this, providing a buggy software which would work for a few days and the client would be happy for now and then it would break down at a later date or do you delay the launch and take the heat but deliver the complete software. Now comes another situation where my manager does not assign me to any important projects or any meaningful work for that matter so what would be my approach to this. I told her about being direct in this situation and confronting my manager and politely explaining the situation. She said what if he/she doesn't give me the time of day to confront them. After she was satisfied with my answer she asked me about my experience at Oculus as a Marketing head and what challenges I faced while leading such a large team. Finally she told me there was one last question or at least that's what she told me. She asked me about my weakness and then based on that created situations. She asked me what if my manager was someone who micromanaged me constantly and check in every 10 minutes what I would do. She reiterated various aspects of this scenario and told me she was done

with the interview after she was satisfied with all my answers. Finally she told me if I had any questions and I asked a couple of questions and I was done.

PRO Tips for HR Round:

1. Think of HR round as a chess match where you have to constantly think, react and plan ahead for every move you make, with the addition that your moves are being constantly judged. My interviewer was someone who was in the HR industry for 15 years and yours would also probably be someone with the same experience so they know people very well, so always be on your guard and say things that actually do align with what you believe in.
2. Be honest but not too honest. This might seem confusing but HR representatives can usually identify when you're lying very easily. Now for the not too honest part, whatever you answer though the actual reason might be something else, mention that, but additionally connect it to the company's values and requirements. For example, for the work from home question some of you might prefer that but the company has work from office policy so align your answer such that you believe in work from home but are open to work from office.
3. Align your answers with the company values and your own experiences. Why this is important is because when you just state facts as an answer but you connect it with an actual experience, it becomes a story which always has great value in interviews not just HR but technical ones too.
4. Another important tip which will help you navigate HR easily is not to keep it one way where they ask and you answer. Try keeping it two-way where you ask them questions based on their questions and your answers and if you are confident enough try adding in a funny remark or two to make the atmosphere less tense.
5. Remember the names of your previous interviewers as it might be asked during HR and it is also a good practice to know it if you do get selected. Usually each interviewer introduces themselves at the start itself but in case someone does not, make it a practice to ask their names at the end of the interview.

3. **Final Screening Round** [9 students were shortlisted for this round]

This interview was taken by the senior management of IDFC and it was more of a formality but still do not take this lightly as one student was eliminated in this round. The interview was online where the interviewer asked me to take him through my resume. I had a project where I had used Selenium so he asked what Selenium was, what it was used for and what was its use case in my project. Then he asked how I usually approached any problem I was given. Then he came to time complexity analysis and asked what it was. He then asked me the purpose of the big O notation and then asked me if I had to find the time complexity of an algorithm how I would approach that. He then asked a couple of questions which I do not remember and then he asked if I had any questions and that was it.

8 students were offered the job at the end

Useful Tips:

1. Let's start with the preparation phase before the placement season. The most important part is DSA this will help you clear a lot of Online Assessments for all the major companies. Start as early as possible, the earlier the better. Also what is more important than starting early is maintaining consistency. I was one of the first people to start DSA during the start of 3rd year but then left it

midway for almost the entire Sem 5. Do not make this mistake, once you start make it a habit to do DSA everyday even if it is just one question.

2. You can follow a sheet like Striver's A2Z Sheet or NeetCode or do a combination of both like I did. Start with Striver's SDE Sheet or NeetCode 150 whichever you are comfortable with if you feel confident about Data Structures or go for A2Z Sheet or NeetCode 250 if your basics aren't clear. For Recursion, DP and Graphs make sure to strictly follow Striver and his respective playlists on the topics as it is the best resource on the internet for these topics. The rest you can do from either.
3. Another aspect of DSA is explaining your approach. You may be amazing at DSA but if you cannot explain your approach none of it is any use. When practicing LeetCode, although this might take additional time, but try explaining your approach in your head while you are solving the question
4. Try to do LeetCode contests if you have the time or you complete DSA early enough to practice time management and make sure to practice company style story based questions for OA practice using ChatGPT. You can also experiment with CP if you enjoy doing LeetCode and DSA although I wouldn't recommend it for those of y'all who are doing it for the sake of placements like I was.
5. Next comes SQL, this may seem like an easy topic but this is very crucial as it is asked in almost all interviews. Start with a basic crash course of SQL like Apna College or some other channel to learn basic topics like GROUP BY, ORDER BY, SELECT, JOINS and other basics. Once you have a basic understanding of these jump directly to SQL 50 from LeetCode as the more you practice the better you will be. For each question in SQL 50 if you don't get the solution, go through the solutions of other people or the editorial by LeetCode if given. Do not directly move to ChatGPT that won't help you understand and explore.
6. For OOPS follow Kunal Kushwaha's playlist for OOPs that is the best there is. There is nothing additional required. If you are also working with some other language like C++ or Python refer to OOPs in those languages through ChatGPT and Google. Do preparation for OOPs toward the end of the preparation phase with 2-3 weeks left for the placement season so as to remember the concepts better. After all of this try doing some OS and CCN if time permits.
7. I would recommend doing an internship or two and if you have already done one, make sure to present it well in your resume as this carries a lot of weight. It basically shows the interviewer that other companies also decided to work with you and you have already worked in a professional environment. Even if you do not have an internship, add 3-4 good and diverse projects in your resume so that you can stand out from the crowd. Keep in mind that everyone is going to do normal web dev projects, so to stand you must do different projects that integrate multiple things and try to do a project that includes an AI workflow.
8. Make sure that you know each of your resume projects inside out and you can talk about them for hours with the interviewer. Try to only add projects that you have actually worked on and even if you do add a project right from the internet which I wouldn't recommend but in extreme cases if you do make sure that you put it into ChatGPT or CoPilot and know every aspect of it.
9. Now for the interview part, once you clear the OA try to get a good night's sleep before the interview day but in case it is your first interview and you have a habit and can manage with less sleep, I would recommend that you prepare well the night before if there is something you haven't. Again I would only recommend this if you have done it a lot of times over the years during exams. I did this exact thing and I was a bit sleepy on the D-Day but it was worth it otherwise I wouldn't have been well prepared, so manage your risk accordingly.
10. On the day of the interview, there can be a possibility that your interview might be scheduled later in the day so during this time keep talking to people around you or do some last minute revision but do not overthink and get tensed about your interview. Even if your friends aren't with you, talk to other people so that you get engaged and it takes the edge off.

11. Lastly remember that no matter how much you prepare there will always be situations that work against you like curveball questions you hadn't expected or a stubborn interviewer or any other situation that you did not expect so always be ready for such things. Also be mentally prepared to face ample rejections before you even get an interview or get placed. I got my first interview after facing more than 6-7 OAs and faced 3 interviews before I got placed and for each of these I managed to reach the final round and then got rejected. Keep in mind that this is a part of the placement process and always be ready to get up and move on.

Resources:

Category	Resource/Platform	Key Strategy/Notes
OA & Aptitude	IndiaBix	Good for topics including (percentages, ratios, time-distance).
DSA	Striver's A2Z DSA Sheet	Understanding patterns is crucial. Always spend 30-45 mins before looking at the solution. I had solved around 75% of the SDE sheet.
Java OOPs	Kunal Kushwaha Playlist & GFG Notes	If you have time, go through the entire playlist as it is very extensive
DBMS	GFG, Code-Help Babbar	Supplement lecture notes with these for fast review.
CN	GFG CN Notes	Supplement lecture notes with these for fast review.
OS	GFG OS Notes	Supplement lecture notes with these for fast review.
SQL	Leetcode 50 questions	This should be enough for most of the on campus roles.
Interview Prep	ChatGPT	Quick and reliable tool to research company background, tech stack, and everything related to your resume or interview answers.
HR	Indiabix+ChatGPT	Use them to prepare for general HR questions. Use LLMs to tailor your answers according to company values.